Travelling abroad with a company laptop

Article KB0010098 | Owner: Security Operations | Subcategory: General | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS laptops (MacBook Pro/Air running macOS 14/15), All Acme-Global issued laptops managed by Intune

Summary

When travelling internationally with an Acme-Global issued laptop, users must ensure the device remains compliant with corporate security policies, maintains access to VPN and MFA, and is protected against loss or theft. This article outlines pre-travel checks, a self-help checklist for users, and the corresponding service-desk workflow for assistance. Follow the steps to avoid connectivity, authentication, or encryption issues while abroad.

Symptoms

- Unable to establish GlobalProtect VPN connection - error "Certificate not trusted" or "Connection timed out"
- MFA push notification not received on Microsoft Authenticator while abroad
- BitLocker recovery key prompt appears after boot
- OneDrive/SharePoint shows "You're offline" or sync errors
- Local Wi-Fi networks block 802.1X authentication

Common causes

- Expired or missing machine certificate for GlobalProtect VPN
- Device not connected to a network that allows outbound HTTPS/443 to vpn.acme.example
- Time-zone drift causing token validation issues for MFA
- BitLocker/TMPM protection triggered due to unexpected hardware change (e.g., docking station)
- Local regulations restricting use of strong encryption or corporate VPN

Pre-Travel Preparation

Before departure, verify that the laptop's GlobalProtect machine certificate is valid (certificates renew yearly). Confirm the device is compliant in Intune - check for pending Windows updates, BitLocker status, and that the latest Defender definitions are installed. Ensure you have enrolled a secondary MFA method (SMS) in case the Authenticator push cannot reach your phone. Back up your BitLocker recovery key from the Intune portal and store it securely (e.g., in a password manager). Finally, test the VPN connection from your home or office network to validate that the client works correctly.

User Self-Help Procedure

Follow these steps to prepare and use your laptop while travelling. Each step can be performed independently; if any step fails, note the error and contact the IT Service Desk.

1. 1. Open Settings -> Accounts -> Access work or school and confirm your device is joined to Azure AD and shows "Managed by Intune".
2. 2. Launch the GlobalProtect client, click the gear icon -> Check for Updates, then select Connect. If the connection fails, note the exact error message.
3. 3. Verify MFA: attempt to sign into https://portal.office.com and confirm you receive a push notification in Microsoft Authenticator. If you do not, choose the SMS backup option.
4. 4. Confirm BitLocker status: open Control Panel -> BitLocker Drive Encryption and ensure the OS drive shows "Protection On". Click Back up your recovery key and save it to your Intune account.
5. 5. Test connectivity to corporate resources: open Outlook, try to send/receive email, and browse to https://intranet.acme.example. Successful sync indicates the device is reachable.

Service-Desk Agent Procedure

When a user reports travel-related laptop issues, follow this workflow to gather information, perform remote checks, and provide guidance. Escalate only after basic troubleshooting fails or when a certificate or compliance issue is identified.

1. 1. Ask the user for the laptop asset tag, current location, and the exact error message(s) they are seeing (VPN, MFA, BitLocker, etc.).

2. 2. Verify Intune compliance status via the Endpoint Manager console: check for pending updates, BitLocker protection, and GlobalProtect certificate expiry date.
3. 3. If the VPN certificate has expired or is missing, issue a temporary machine certificate through the PKI portal and instruct the user to reinstall the GlobalProtect client with the new profile.
4. 4. For MFA problems, confirm the user has a valid Temporary Access Pass (TAP) issued by IAM; if not, request one and guide the user through the TAP sign-in process.
5. 5. If BitLocker recovery is requested, retrieve the recovery key from Intune and provide it to the user, reminding them to re-enable protection after resolving the underlying cause (e.g., docking station change).
6. 6. Document all steps taken in the ticket and advise the user to retest connectivity after each action.

Verification and Post-Travel Checks

After returning to an Acme office or a trusted network, users should verify that the laptop remains compliant and that any temporary measures are cleared. This helps prevent lingering configuration drift.

1. 1. Connect to the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi (802.1X) and confirm automatic login succeeds.
2. 2. Launch GlobalProtect and ensure the connection uses the corporate machine certificate (check Details -> Certificate).
3. 3. Run Windows Update or macOS Software Update to apply any patches missed while away.
4. 4. In the Intune portal, verify the device shows "Compliant" and that the BitLocker status is "Protection On".
5. 5. If a Temporary Access Pass was used, sign out and sign back in using regular credentials to confirm MFA push works normally.

Troubleshooting Common Issues

Below are frequent scenarios encountered by travellers and the recommended first-response actions. If the issue persists after these steps, escalate to the appropriate specialist team.

VPN connection fails with certificate error - Ensure the laptop's system clock is accurate (time-zone set correctly). An incorrect clock can cause certificate validation to fail. If the clock is correct, check the GlobalProtect client logs for "certificate not trusted" and contact the Service Desk to renew the machine certificate.

No MFA push received - Verify that the device has internet connectivity (open a browser). If connectivity is present, try the SMS backup method. If neither works, ask the IAM team for a Temporary Access Pass.

BitLocker recovery screen appears - This often follows a change in docking station, external GPU, or BIOS update. Retrieve the recovery key from Intune, enter it, and then check TPM status in the tpm.msc console. If TPM reports a problem, create a ticket with Desktop Support for hardware inspection.

OneDrive/SharePoint shows offline - Confirm that the device can reach *.sharepoint.com and *.office.com via a web browser. If reachable, restart the OneDrive client. If not, validate VPN or DirectAccess connectivity.

Local Wi-Fi blocks 802.1X - Some hotels or conference centres disable 802.1X on guest networks. In such cases, connect to the ACME-Guest SSID (if available) or use a personal hotspot to establish VPN, then switch back to the corporate SSID when possible.

When to escalate

If the user cannot resolve VPN, MFA, or BitLocker issues after following the self-help steps, or if the device shows non-compliant status in Intune, escalate to Security Operations. Include the laptop asset tag, current location, exact error messages, Intune compliance report, and any relevant logs (GlobalProtect, MFA, BitLocker).

Keywords: travel, international, laptop, VPN, GlobalProtect, MFA, BitLocker, self-help, service desk, Security Operations